

Copyright Literacy Skills of LIS Students in Norway

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Abstract. This paper presents findings from a study on copyright literacy skills of Library and Information Studies (LIS) students in Norway. It surveyed bachelor, master and PhD students at the Oslo Metropolitan University which is the only Norwegian institution offering LIS education at all levels. This web-based study was conducted in April 2018. It was based on the multi-national survey called "Copyright Literacy of LIS Students (CoLIS)" that intends to gather data about the knowledge and awareness of LIS students regarding copyright related issues in many countries. The survey findings show a gap between the expected level of knowledge and the actual one, and they will be used as a starting point for discussions with the LIS education community.

Keywords: Copyright literacy · LIS students · Information literacy · LIS education · Norway

1 Introduction

The information society and constantly changing digital technologies make high demands for adequate knowledge and skills to meet these changes. Among others, students and staff of higher education institutions are required to have excellent competencies for dealing with copyright issues.

A few years ago, colleagues in Bulgaria initiated the multi-national project/survey "Copyright Policies of Libraries and Other Cultural Institutions" [1]. Norway was among the many countries which conducted this survey, and professionals in archives, museums and libraries identified serious gaps in their knowledge and awareness of copyright laws and issues [2]. This study is now followed by another multi-national study, this time focusing on copyright literacy skills among Library and Information Science (LIS) students, called "Copyright Literacy of LIS Students (CoLIS)" [3].

In Norway, the authors conducted this survey among LIS students of the Oslo Metropolitan University in April 2018, and the survey data were analysed in May 2018.

This paper will present a summary of the key findings of this web-based survey that includes questions about familiarity, knowledge, awareness, and opinions on copyright related issues, but also seeks demographic information on respondents. The findings are intended to be a starting point for the LIS education community to take actions to fill

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possible gaps in copyright skills of library and information science students. The results of the study will also allow further cross-country comparisons when findings from other countries will be available.

2 Methodology

In order to evaluate LIS students' knowledge and awareness level of copyright related issues a web-based survey was developed on the LimeSurvey platform by the CoLIS team [3].

The questionnaire comprises two parts. The first part consists of four questions requiring demographic information like gender and level of studies (i.e. first year, third year, PhD). The second part comprises nine questions about general copyright literacy skills. Students could tick off multiple answers to seven of these questions. One question asked for opinions about various statements and students had to choose between "agree", "neutral" or "disagree" in their answers, while another question wanted to know "What is the name of the copyright law in your country?".

The original survey was created in English. Discussion with LIS teachers at Oslo Metropolitan University led to the decision to translate the survey into both versions of written Norwegian, Bokmål and Nynorsk.

The dissemination of the URL to the survey was carried out by email in April 2018 to 362 LIS students of the Oslo Metropolitan University. All students at Bachelor, Master and PhD levels were recruited at this university only, because there are no other higher education institutions in Norway that offer Library and Information Science studies at all levels. Unfortunately only 46 students completed the survey, even though 359 of the 362 students had opened it. It is not clear to the authors why relatively few students responded, since a reminder was also sent to the students. One possible explanation is that the survey was sent out rather late in the term, at a time when the students were getting closer to their exams. In addition, individual LIS teachers were not asked to promote the survey. Communication about the survey occured between the head of the LIS institute and the authors only.

The gathered data were entered, coded, and analysed using the SPSS statistical package.

3 Findings

3.1 Demographic Information

Out of the 46 respondents there are 34 female, ten male and two who ticked off "I do not want to disclose".

Ten students are in their first year of studying, nine in their second year and 15 students in their third year. Twelve students were on Master level when answering the survey, while none of the PhD students responded.

3.2 Knowledge and Awareness of Copyright Literacy

As already mentioned above, the second part of the study comprises nine questions about general copyright knowledge and awareness. The authors will not show the answers to all nine questions, but only to the six with the most interesting answers.

The second question in the second part of the questionnaire asked "Are you familiar with the following" – followed by 15 possible answers. Students could tick off all answers that apply.

The following table shows the results for seven of these 15 answers (Table 1).

Table 1. Degree of familiarity with copyright related issues (N = 46)

Sub-questions	Yes % (N)	No % (N)
Copyright and related law – national level	89,1 (41)	10,9 (5)
Copyright and related law – international level	45,7 (21)	54,3 (25)
Copyright related institutions – national level	39,1 (18)	60,9 (28)
Copyright related institutions – international level	23,9 (11)	76,1 (35)
Creative Commons Licenses	76,1 (35)	23,9 (11)
Copyright issues regarding virtual services within e-learning practices	26,1 (12)	73,9 (34)
Copyright issues regarding materials from public domain	21,7 (10)	78,3 (36)

When asked where students would search for more information about copyright related issues, 14 answers could be ticked off. Figure 1 shows the results in detail. It is clear that students would mainly choose books, articles or websites to learn more about copyright. They would not use international institutions/organisations like WIPO (World Intellectual Property Organization), eIFL (Electronic Information for Libraries

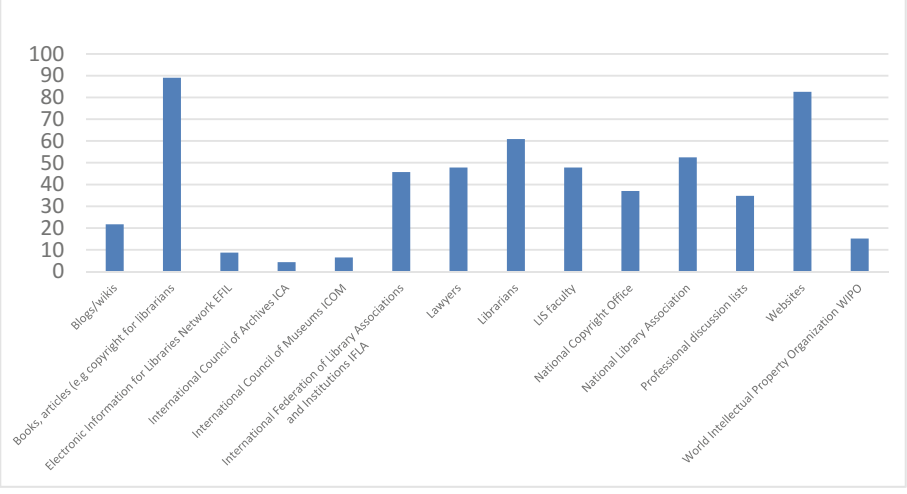


Fig. 1. Percentages responding "yes" to the question "If you want to learn about intellectual property/copyright and its relation with the activities of the cultural institutions (libraries, archives, museums), where will you search for information?" (N = 46)

Network), ICA (International Council of Archives), or ICOM (International Council of Museums) as sources for more information, presumably because most students do not know these organisations.

Students were also asked the following question: "In your opinion within LIS education which of the following levels is appropriate for introducing Intellectual Property issues?"

The majority of the responding students - 93,5% (N = 43) - think that copyright related issues should be introduced at Bachelor level, while eight students suggested that this topic should be taught at Master level. That means, a few students think copyright issues should be part of both Bachelor and Master studies.

The analysis of answers to the question about topics on which students have been educated during their studies showed interesting and surprising results. It emerges that students at all levels have quite different opinions on what they have been educated about regarding copyright issues (see Table 2). But it is difficult to know the reasons for that.

Table 2. Responses to "Please specify the topics/issues you have been educated/trained on in your department?" (N = 46)

Sub-questions	Yes % (N)	No % (N)
Copyright and related law – national level	93,5 (43)	6,5 (3)
Copyright and related law – international level	23,9 (11)	76,1 (35)
Copyright related institutions – national level	39,1 (18)	60,9 (28)
Copyright related institutions – international level	10,9 (5)	89,1 (41)
Copyright related initiatives – national level	19,6 (9)	80,4 (37)
Copyright related initiatives – international level	2,2 (1)	97,8 (45)
Copyright related information sources	43,5 (20)	56,5 (26)
Clearing right holder(s)	23,9 (11)	76,1 (35)
Licensing for information sources (e.g. for digital resources – databases etc.)	54,3 (25)	45,7 (21)
Copyright issues regarding the development of institutional repositories	17,4 (8)	82,6 (38)
Copyright issues regarding virtual services within e-learning practices	21,7 (10)	78,3 (38)
Creative Commons Licenses	63,0 (29)	37,0 (17)
Copyright issues related to open access, open data	71,7 (33)	28,3 (13)
Fair use	47,8 (22)	52,2 (24)
Copyright issues regarding digitization	43,5 (20)	56,5 (26)
Copyright issues regarding materials from public domain	26,1 (12)	73,9 (34)
Copyright issues regarding out-of-print works	15,2 (7)	84,8 (39)
Copyright issues regarding orphan works	10,9 (5)	89,1 (41)
Exceptions and limitations related to copyright	28,3 (13)	71,7 (33)

Responses to "Please specify the topics/issues you think LIS students should learn before they graduate and start working in a cultural heritage institution" were very interesting too, in particular because the students were divided in their opinions about

what knowledge they should have when finishing their studies. For example, most students think they should have skills about copyright law(s) on a national level, licensing for information sources, creative commons licenses, copyright issues related to open access and open data, fair use, copyright issues regarding digitisation, and exceptions and limitations related to copyright when graduating.

However, there are quite a few students who think they do not need knowledge about copyright related institutions (both on a national and international level), clearing right holders, copyright issues regarding the development of institutional repositories and virtual services within e-learning practices, and copyright issues regarding materials from public domain as well as orphan works. See Table 3 for detailed results.

Table 3. Responses to "Please specify the topics/issues you think LIS students should learn before they graduate and start working in a cultural heritage institution?" (N = 46)

Sub-questions	Yes % (N)	No % (N)
Copyright and related law – national level	95,5 (44)	4,5 (2)
Copyright and related law – international level	76,1 (35)	23,9 (11)
Copyright related institutions – national level	60,9 (28)	39,1 (18)
Copyright related institutions – international level	34,8 (16)	65,2 (30)
Copyright related initiatives – national level	41,3 (19)	58,7 (27)
Copyright related initiatives – international level	34,8 (16)	65,2 (30)
Copyright related information sources	69,6 (32)	30,4 (14)
Clearing right holder(s)	45,7 (21)	54,3 (25)
Licensing for information sources (e.g. for digital resources – databases etc.)	84,8 (39)	15,2 (7)
Copyright issues regarding the development of institutional repositories	50,0 (23)	50,0 (23)
Copyright issues regarding virtual services within e-learning practices	67,4 (31)	32,6 (15)
Creative Commons Licenses	80,4 (37)	19,6 (9)
Copyright issues related to open access, open data	91,3 (42)	8,7 (4)
Fair use	80,4 (37)	19,6 (9)
Copyright issues regarding digitization	78,3 (36)	21,7 (10)
Copyright issues regarding materials from public domain	63,0 (29)	37,0 (17)
Copyright issues regarding out-of-print works	69,6 (32)	30,4 (14)
Copyright issues regarding orphan works	60,9 (28)	39,1 (18)
Exceptions and limitations related to copyright	73,9 (34)	26,1 (12)

When comparing the findings in Table 2 ("Please specify the topics/issues you have been educated/trained on in your department") and Table 3 ("Please specify the topics/issues you think LIS students should learn before they graduate and start working in a cultural heritage institution"), one can see that some responses to these two survey questions are concordant while others are not.

For example, 95,5% of the responding students think that "Copyright and related law – national level" is important, and 93,5% agree that they have been educated in this topic. 91,3% of the students think that "Copyright issues related to open access, open

data" is a subject LIS students should learn about during their studies, while 71,7% of the students responded that they have been educated in this.

Likewise, the majority of responding students seem to think that "Copyright related institutions - international level" or "Copyright related initiatives - international level" are less important (65,2%), and 10,9% respectively 2,2% say they have not been taught on these topics.

For other issues there are quite divergent responses. For example, 50% of the responding students think "Copyright issues regarding the development of institutional repositories" should be taught as part of LIS education, but only 17,4% state they have learned about this. Similar answers were given for "Copyright issues regarding materials from public domain". 63% of the responding students think they should have learned about this area before graduating, while only 21,6% say they have been taught the topic during their studies.

The students were also asked about the name of the copyright law in Norway. Since the survey questions were translated into Norwegian, the responses were as well in the Norwegian language. The correct name of the law is "Lov om opphavsrett til åndsverk", and the shortened name (according to the official web page) is "Åndsverkloven" [4]. Seven students do not know or do not remember the name of this law, and five students give the Norwegian copyright law a somewhat different name, while 34 students know the correct name or the official shortened name.

This seems to indicate that most students have some knowledge of the national copyright law, even if knowing the name of the law does not imply knowing the content of the law.

4 Discussions and Conclusions

The main aim of this study on Copyright Literacy was to investigate the knowledge and awareness of copyright issues of LIS students in Norway. The web-based questionnaire was sent to 362 students at Oslo Metropolitan University, and 46 students completed the survey. At that time there were ten students who were at their first year of studies, nine at the second year, 15 at the third year and 12 students at master level. The authors can only guess if the students who responded were the ones most interested in copyright issues, most cooperative, or the ones with time on their hands.

Since only 12,7% of all LIS students at Oslo Metropolitan University completed the survey, it cannot be argued that the results are significant. The authors think however that the survey results are an indication of a gap between the topics students have been educated on, and thus should have knowledge about, and the actual knowledge and awareness the students possess.

It is in particular interesting that students at all levels have quite different opinions about what they have been educated on regarding copyright issues during their studies and what they should learn before graduating. Likewise it is very interesting and surprising that the students would rather ask the National Library Association(s) or IFLA, the International Federation of Library Associations and Institutions, about copyright issues than professional discussion lists, the National Copyright Office

(which in Norway is covered by the National Library and an institution called Kopinor) or their own teachers.

The findings are intended to be a starting point for the LIS education community to take actions to fill the gaps in copyright skills. They will be discussed in detail with teachers of the Department of Archivistics, Library and Information Sciences at the Oslo Metropolitan University. In order to determine the actual copyright knowledge of LIS students in Norway, an appropriate knowledge test should be conducted, as well as face-to-face interviews with students. But that would be another research study.

Earlier studies have already shown that there is a gap in the copyright knowledge of librarians in Norway [2]. However, copyright issues are highly specialised and complicated, and it should not be expected that newly graduated librarians will be "experts" in the field.

The survey also reveals that among other things the students would turn to the national library association(s) for help when needing more information on copyright issues. Therefore, we propose to approach the Norwegian Library Association's subcommittee on copyright and ask for collaboration, together with the National Library of Norway and "Kopinor" (which licences the use of copyright protected works on behalf of authors and publishers). Also the Council for Academic Libraries in Norway, and the Norwegian County Library Association (supporting public libraries and school libraries in their regions) would be good partners in order to start a life-long learning initiative for librarians, which might be online training including two or more modules, one basic and one or two more specialised.

The results of the study will also allow further cross-country comparisons, as soon as the results from other participants in the multi-national survey will be available.

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